

Negotiating tactics

Worksheet

A The phrases below could all be said by a customer at exactly the same point in a negotiation. What is the main difference between them?

- a If we increased our order to 500 units it would mean much more risk for us. We don't know if this product will sell in our market. We would expect a better price.
- b Supposing we increased our order? What would be your reaction?
- c If you could give us a better price, and perhaps be a little more flexible with your terms, then we might find a way to increase our order.
- d If we increase our order to 500 units, will you give us 90 dollars per unit?
- e If we increase our order to 500 units, will you give us a better price?

Now put the phrases in sequence, from 1 (the most open and flexible) to 5 (the most direct and specific):

1 _____ 2 _____ 3 _____ 4 _____ 5 _____

B Look back at phrases a–e from Section A. Which phrases:

- 1 show the customer preparing his/her case with an explanation first?
- 2 show the use of tentative (uncertain, indirect) language?
- 3 would you expect to hear nearer to the beginning of the negotiation?
- 4 show the linking of issues (asking for something in return for giving something)?

C Match examples 1–6 with tactics a–f below.

- 1 Good, that's a step forward. Shall we move on to talk about the transport arrangements?
 - 2 Well, I could do that, but it would involve some changes to our production schedule.
 - 3 Well, I suppose that helps a little.
 - 4 If we split the shipment in two parts you wouldn't have such high storage costs.
 - 5 Normally we don't do that, but I suppose in this situation it might be possible. I don't know what my boss would say!
 - 6 Let me see. That would save us about 500 dollars a month. At least that's something.
- a Emphasizing the 'cost' to you. _____
 - b Showing how something you want gives them a benefit. _____
 - c Saying that your concession is not normal. _____
 - d Moving on quickly after winning a point. _____
 - e Breaking down large figures to make them seem less. _____
 - f Devaluing the importance of their concession. _____

- Can you add any other tactics or tricks?

D In your next negotiation remember to:

- Choose carefully whether to be open or specific in your offers and requests
- Link issues
- Use tentative language to show that you are uncertain. (Perhaps you will get an extra concession?)
- Try some of the ideas from section C